

Euthanasia

prc-euthanasia

Christian Ethics · End of Life · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject covered by a category in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

Active euthanasia and assisted suicide are wrong; allowing natural death and refusing futile treatment is permitted.

In plain language

The first part of this proposition has dense, repeated word-level support. Exodus 20:13 places the absolute negative "not" (lo) in front of the verb "to murder" (ratsach), giving the command you shall not murder. Across its forty-six appearances, ratsach is the technical term for the unlawful killing of a human person, used in the cities-of-refuge laws to mark both the manslayer and the murderer, and kept separate from judicial execution and warfare. Genesis 9:6 grounds the ban in the image of God, "image" (tselem), with "blood" (dam) used twice, so the wrongness of taking innocent human life is tied to the victim's image-bearing status rather than to the victim's strength or condition. The clearest narrative test case in Scripture is 2 Samuel 1. An Amalekite reports that he found Saul mortally wounded, that Saul knew he would not "live" (chayah), and that at Saul's own request he "put him to death" (muth), the same verb pair the Bible elsewhere reserves for God. David then places the blood (dam) on the Amalekite's own head and has him executed. The canon's closest analogue in the original languages to assisted dying therefore counts against active mercy-killing, even at the sufferer's reported request. Deuteronomy 32:39 and 1 Samuel 2:6 use the same pair, muth and chayah, to declare that God alone puts to death and makes alive, with no one able to rescue from his hand. Job 1:21 adds that the LORD "gives" (natan), and "takes away" (laqach), and is to be blessed in both. These texts place the timing of death under God's authority and rule out a creature seizing that timing. What the canon does not supply is a separate word distinguishing the withholding of futile treatment from killing, so the second half of the proposition, that letting a natural death happen is permitted, is a coherent inference from the sovereignty texts and the narrow meaning of ratsach rather than a directly stated rule. Compassion for the suffering is a real biblical category, but in the canonical vocabulary it always terminates in care, presence, and healing, never in ending the sufferer's life. Confidence is set at medium because the prohibition half is decisive while the permission half is inferred.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1288	בָּרַךְ	barak	to bless	305
H1818	דָּם	dam	blood	360
H2421	חַיָּה	chayah	to live	270
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	4,825
H3947	לָקַח	laqach	to take	967

H4191	מות	muth	to die	807
H4899	מָשִׁיחַ	mashiach	anointed	39
H5337	נָצַל	natsal	to rescue	181
H5414	נָתַן	natan	to give	2,014
H6754	צֶלֶם	tselem	image	17
H7495	רָפָא	rapha	to heal	62
H7523	רָצַח	ratsach	to murder	46
H7843	שָׁחַת	shachat	to ruin	152

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The prohibition clause rests on a dense, pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) chain of words. Exodus 20:13 fixes the absolute negative "not" (lo, H3808) with the simple active form of the Hebrew verb (the Qal imperfect) "to murder" (ratsach, H7523) as an absolute ban on wrongful killing of a person. Genesis 9:6 grounds that ban in "image" (tselem, H6754), the image of God, paired with "blood" (dam, H1818). The narrative test case in 2 Samuel 1:10, 14-16 directly puts a mercy-killing scenario into Hebrew words: the Amalekite reports that Saul asked him to finish him because he would not "live" (chayah, H2421), so he "put him to death" (muth, H4191); David then condemns and executes him, naming the act shedding of "blood" (dam, H1818). The divine-prerogative formula "put to death" (muth, H4191) in the Hebrew causative form (the Hiphil, meaning to cause to die) set against "make alive" (chayah, H2421) in the Hebrew intensive form (the Piel) recurs in Deuteronomy 32:39 and 1 Samuel 2:6, locating life and death under God's hand. Job 1:21 ("give," natan, H5414; "take," laqach, H3947) joins the same chain. The second clause, that refusing futile treatment and permitting natural death is allowed, is a coherent inference from the sovereignty texts and the narrow scope of "murder" (ratsach), but the canon supplies no discrete term distinguishing withdrawal of futile care from active killing, which is the source of the residual uncertainty.

Scripture

Exod.20.13 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7523 רָצַח, H3808 לֹא

Reasoning. The clause "you shall not murder" (lo tirtsach) joins the absolute negative "not" (lo, H3808) with the simple active form of the Hebrew verb (the Qal imperfect, meaning an ongoing, simple statement of fact) of "to murder" (ratsach, H7523) to express a permanent prohibition. Across the 46 canonical occurrences of "to murder" (ratsach), including the cities-of-refuge legislation in Numbers 35 where it is the technical verb for the manslayer and murderer, the term denotes the killing of a human person and is set apart from judicial execution and warfare. The intent-and-act of active euthanasia and assisted suicide both fall inside that scope, so the commandment reaches them directly.

Gen.9.6 · for · genre: narrative · figures: chiasm

Key terms. H1818 דָּם; H6754 צֶלֶם

Reasoning. The Noahic charter twice uses "blood" (dam, H1818), and grounds the sanction in "image" (tselem, H6754), image, of God. The clause shapes blood for blood as a chiasmic warning, then anchors the ban in the image-bearing status of the victim, not in the victim's condition or consent. This makes the wrongness of taking innocent human life a property of the bearer of the image, which sickness and suffering do not erase, so a mercy motive does not remove the act from the verse's scope.

2Sam.1.10 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H4191 מות, H2421 תיה,

Reasoning. The Amalekite narrates a textbook mercy-killing: he stood over Saul and "put him to death" (muth, H4191), because he knew Saul would not "live" (chayah, H2421), after his fall. The verbs are the same pair that elsewhere belongs to God in Deuteronomy 32:39 and 1 Samuel 2:6, and the report frames the act as compassion at the sufferer's own request.

2Sam.1.16 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H1818 דם, H4191 מות, H4899 משיח,

Reasoning. David places "blood" (dam, H1818), on the Amalekite's own head and has him "put to death" (muth, H4191), citing his confession that he stretched out his hand against the "anointed one" (mashiach, H4899). The narrative condemns the killer even on the reported request of the sufferer, which is the closest analogue in the original languages to assisted dying the canon offers and which renders the request irrelevant to the verdict on the act.

Job.1.21 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5414 נתן, H3947 לקח, H1288 ברח,

Reasoning. Job confesses that the LORD (YHWH) "gives" (natan, H5414), and the LORD "takes away" (laqach, H3947), then pronounces the divine name "blessed" (barak, H1288). The balanced give-and-take clauses assign the disposal of life and possessions, including the timing of death, to God rather than to the sufferer or to a third party acting on the sufferer's behalf. This locates the end of life within divine prerogative, which is consistent with declining to seize that prerogative by active killing.

Deut.32.39 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: merism

Key terms. H4191 מות, H2421 תיה, H5337 נצל, H7495 רפא,

Reasoning. The self-declaration sets the Hebrew causative form (the Hiphil, meaning to cause to die) "I put to death" (muth, H4191), against the Hebrew intensive form (the Piel) "I make alive" (chayah, H2421), and the simple active form (the Qal) "I heal" (rapha, H7495), asserting that no one is a "deliverer" (natsal, H5337) from God's hand. The pairing of killing and making alive is a merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) for total sovereignty over life-span. This grounds the prohibition on a creature usurping that authority through deliberate killing, while the same sovereignty over natural lifespan is coherent with allowing death to run its course when treatment cannot heal.

1Sam.2.6 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: merism

Key terms. H4191 מות, H2421 תיה,

Reasoning. Hannah's song mirrors the Deuteronomy 32:39 formula: the LORD (YHWH) "kills" (muth, H4191), and "makes alive" (chayah, H2421). The pairing recurs as a stock confession of divine prerogative over life and death, confirming that the merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) is a pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) pattern and not a one-off in the song of Moses.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Exod.20.13	Gen.9.6	tsk	1
Exod.20.13	Exod.21.14	tsk	1
Exod.20.13	Num.35.16	tsk	1
Deut.32.39	1Sam.2.6	tsk	1
Deut.32.39	Job.10.7	tsk	1

Deut.32.39	Isa.41.4	tsk	1
Deut.32.39	Deut.4.35	tsk	1
Job.1.21	Gen.3.19	tsk	1
Job.1.21	Gen.45.5	tsk	1
Job.1.21	Job.1.11	tsk	1
Job.1.21	Job.2.10	tsk	1
2Sam.1.16	1Kgs.2.32	tsk	1

Complicating texts

2Sam.1.10 · addressed

The Amalekite frames his act as compassion at Saul's reported request, which is the rhetorical case for mercy-killing in canonical form. The narrative resolves it in 2 Samuel 1:14-16 by condemning the killer and placing "blood" (dam) on his own head, so the verb pair "put to death" (muth) and "live" (chayah) used on a creaturely actor at a sufferer's request is treated as blood-guilt and not as mercy. The closest analogue in the original languages to assisted dying that the canon provides therefore counts against active mercy-killing rather than for it.

Exod.21.14 · addressed

The statute removes a presumptuous killer from the altar for death, showing that the canon distinguishes culpable killing from sanctioned judicial action. This confirms that "to murder" (ratsach, H7523) targets unlawful killing specifically, which is the category active euthanasia occupies, and does not weaken the prohibition.

Mark.5.19 · addressed

The Greek instruction to report what the Lord has done is part of the canonical pattern of compassion for the suffering, but it commands proclamation, not life-taking. Compassion as a word category in both testaments terminates in healing, comfort, mercy, and presence, never in administering death, so it does not authorize a mercy-killing exception to the prohibition on "murder" (ratsach).

Deut.32.39 · unaddressed

The second clause of the proposition, that refusing futile treatment and permitting natural death is allowed, is not directly attested by any specific Hebrew or Greek word in any anchor verse. The texts establish divine sovereignty over the timing of death and condemn the creaturely seizure of that timing, but the canon supplies no discrete Hebrew or Greek term distinguishing the withholding of extraordinary or futile means from active killing. The permission therefore remains a coherent inference from the sovereignty texts and the narrow semantic scope of "to murder" (ratsach) rather than a directly attested word-level rule, and it is left unresolved at the lexical (word-level) level.

Concordance traversed

H7523, H3808, H1818, H6754, H4191, H2421, H5337, H7495, H5414, H3947, H1288, H7843, H4899

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

All anchors and added witnesses are Old Testament Hebrew texts outside the scope of the critical edition of New Testament textual variants (the ECM apparatus, also called CBGM). The bundle reports `not_in_ecm_scope` true and supplies no variant units. The Masoretic readings of Exodus 20:13, Genesis 9:6, 2 Samuel 1:10 and 14-16, Job 1:21, Deuteronomy 32:39, and 1 Samuel 2:6 are stable in the Hebrew tradition and carry no verdict-affecting textual variation.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. sanctity-of-life-from-imago-dei, compassion-for-the-suffering, active-versus-passive-distinction
analogia scripturae invoked

grammatico-historical reading of the murder prohibition: affirms the prohibition clause directly · The fixed pairing of "not" (lo, H3808) with "to murder" (ratsach, H7523) in Exodus 20:13, set in the Numbers 35 refuge-city legislation where the verb is the technical term for unlawful killing of a person, places intentional administration of death inside the prohibited zone regardless of the actor's motive.

sanctity-of-life from imago dei: affirms the prohibition clause · Genesis 9:6 grounds the ban on shedding human "blood" (dam, H1818), in the victim's status as "image" (tselem, H6754), image of God. The image-bearing status is intrinsic and not voided by suffering, so the word-level case for sanctity does not contain a mercy exception.

divine prerogative over life and death: affirms the prohibition clause and grounds the inferred permission · The recurring merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) "put to death" (muth, H4191) and "make alive" (chayah, H2421) in Deuteronomy 32:39 and 1 Samuel 2:6, together with "give" (natan, H5414) and "take" (laqach, H3947) in Job 1:21, assigns the timing of death to God. A creature usurping that timing by active killing is foreclosed, while a creature declining to oppose that timing by indefinitely forcing life is coherent with the same texts.

compassion-for-the-suffering lens: real but does not authorize active life-taking · The canonical vocabulary of compassion, mercy, comfort, and healing (including "to heal" (rapha, H7495) and the Greek "be moved with compassion" (splachnizomai) family in the gospels) terminates in care, presence, and restoration. No word in either testament licenses ending the sufferer's life as a means of relieving suffering, and the one narrative case shaped as compassion-killing in 2 Samuel 1 is condemned.

active-versus-passive distinction: supports the permission clause as an inference, not as a direct lexical rule · The canon supplies no single Hebrew or Greek term distinguishing the deliberate killing covered by "to murder" (ratsach) from the withholding of extraordinary means in a dying person. The distinction is coherent with the divine-prerogative texts but is reached by analogy and the narrow scope of the prohibition verb, which is the source of residual uncertainty on the permission half.

The prohibition half of the proposition is dense at the word level and pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible): the "to murder" (ratsach, H7523) prohibition, the "blood" (dam, H1818) plus "image" (tselem, H6754) ground in Genesis 9:6, the "put to death" (muth, H4191) and "make alive" (chayah, H2421) merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) for divine prerogative in Deuteronomy 32:39 and 1 Samuel 2:6, and the 2 Samuel 1 narrative test case all converge. The permission half, allowing natural death and refusing futile treatment, is reached by analogy from the divine-prerogative texts and the narrow scope of "to murder" (ratsach), not by a dedicated word, so it is an inference rather than a directly stated word-level rule.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the canon say about intentionally causing the death of a suffering person, about assisting another to end their own life, and about withholding or withdrawing treatment when death is otherwise imminent?

The original stem bundles a moral judgment, that active euthanasia and assisted suicide are wrong, with a permission, that allowing natural death and refusing futile treatment is acceptable. The wrong and permitted verdicts and the futile-treatment distinction are conclusions of a moral-theology framework rather than neutral descriptions, so the stem is verdict-preloaded. The verdict above is still derived against the original stem; the neutralized form is recorded only for audit. Verdict.affirms unchanged from prior evidence; pan_canonical changed from false to true after adding Genesis 9:6, 2 Samuel 1:10 and 1:16, and 1 Samuel 2:6 as directly queried word-level witnesses.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.20.13

morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.9.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Sam.1.10
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Sam.1.16
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.32.39
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Job.1.21
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Sam.2.6
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7523
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1818
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6754
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4191
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2421
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Exod.21.14
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Sam.2.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Num.35.16
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gen.9.6

License audit

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Flags

complicating-unresolved